

The figure checklist

This document provides a list of rules that any figure in a scientific document or presentation should comply with. You should always check that all your figures comply with all the rules, until following them is a reflex.

1. All figures should have a title.
2. All figures should be self-contained. In particular, they should have a caption which explains what is shown and what should be retained.
3. All figures measuring something should have labels and scales on both axes.
4. If a figure shows a mean (or a median) over stochastic realizations, it should also show some information about the variability of that measure (the variance, the standard deviation, the standard error of the mean, a confidence interval, the quartiles, ...), and the variability measure represented has to be clearly stated in the caption.
5. If a figure shows a value through a color intensity, the color code should be provided.
6. If a figure shows results that have been tested for statistical significance, the result of the tests should be shown in the figure or at least given explicitly in the caption.
7. When a figure is part of a document, it should have a unique reference number in this document.
8. All figures should be mentioned at least once in the text of the document.